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China's Soft Power Strategy: Education as an Apparatus of Influence in Southeast Asia

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Abstract

Soft power has become a ubiquitous concept in international affairs and an important analytical tool in foreign policy. While there is abundant scholarship on the theoretical aspects of soft power, limited attention has been allocated for analyzing the intersections of soft power and education as a state-sanctioned tool of diplomacy. In view of this gap, this work examines the concept of soft power in the context of China. Specifically, this work maps out the strategies used by China in positioning its higher education sector as an apparatus of influence toward Southeast Asia. In addition, I unpacked how it is leveraging its universities as part of its soft power strategy. I argue that China's educational diplomacy hinges on three pillars: increased student recruitment, offshore campuses and programs of Chinese universities, and Confucius Institutes. Through its soft power strategy, China is continuously influencing the regional and global order and attempting to alleviate discontent among its neighbors.

Keywords

Soft power, international student mobility, Sino-ASEAN relations, Chinese diplomacy, double first class

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Introduction

Soft power has become ubiquitous in international affairs (Chen et al., 2009) and a central analytic term in discussions related to foreign policy (Wilson III, 2008). However, little attention has been given to how tools and resources are utilized by states as part of their soft power agenda. While Joseph Nye is generally credited for coining the term, his soft power concept has subsequently undergone iterations and transformations. Some scholars have critiqued soft power as a catch-all term to refer to vast collections of cultural and political activities (Gilbert, 2017) and dismissed it as "public relations management in an international context" (Kearn, 2011, p. 66). Despite these assessments, soft power theory critically highlights overlooked aspects of international relations (Lee, 2009). It foregrounds other issues such as "national image promotion, normative power promotion, and imagined power" (Breslin, 2011, p. 2).

This work examines the concept of soft power in the context of China. Particularly, I map out the strategies of how education is deployed to Southeast Asia to improve China's regional reputation. Although there is abundant scholarship on the theoretical aspects of soft power, limited attention has been allotted to analyzing the intersections of soft power and education as a state-sanctioned tool of diplomacy. Yang (2010) and Lo and Pan (2021) maintain that there is a dearth of scholarship that expounds on China's projection of soft power through higher education. There is also a gap in examining Sino-ASEAN relations in the aspect of higher education (Yang, 2012).

Consequently, this article seeks to answer the following questions: First, how does China leverage higher education as a form of soft power? Second, what are the nuances of China's soft power approach toward Southeast Asia? In order to provide a comprehensive examination of Chinese soft power and its projection to Southeast Asia, I analyzed an assemblage of data on China's higher education sector and subsequently synthesized recent studies on China's approach to soft power deployment. The succeeding section of this article delineates the concept of power

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in international relations and elaborates on the major critiques of soft power theory. The third and fourth sections examine the multifaceted components of China's education strategy and developments in higher education policy. Lastly, I demonstrate how China is deploying education as part of its soft power strategy in Southeast Asia.

The Dimensions of Soft Power in International Relations

The introduction of soft power in the lexicon of international relations has transformed the way the discipline perceives the capability of states in the international system. As it currently stands, "soft power occupies a prominent place in international relations, foreign policy, and security studies" (Solomon, 2014, p. 720). Generally, I consider power as the ability to obtain outcomes through the deployment of both tangible and intangible state resources. Joseph Nye formally defined power as "the ability to affect others to get the outcomes one wants, and that can be done by coercion, payment or attraction" (Nye, 2012, p. 151). He further delineated power as either hard power or soft power. Hard power, which is coercive in nature, requires the use of force or threat and is generally conveyed through economic and military might (Kroenig et al., 2010). On the other hand, soft power is the ability to achieve the desired goals or outcomes through the process of attraction (Nye, 2009, p. 160). Specifically, it is the ability to influence other states through various means aside from military activities or direct financial inducements (Lai, 2012).

While Joseph Nye has been mostly credited for proposing the term soft power, other scholars have already intimated similar concepts. For example, E. H. Carr puts forward the notion that the "power of opinion" is important in the achievement of political objectives and is closely linked with economic and military power (Kartikasari, 2018). Kenneth Waltz also asserts the notion that the deployment of hard power may not be the most efficient instrument in achieving the desired state outcomes (Rawnsley, 2016). In a similar vein, Hans Morgenthau opines that states should also be cognizant of the public opinion of the world in order to maintain their international status (Lee, 2011).

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There are three sources of soft power: culture, political values, and foreign policy (Nye, 2005). In terms of culture, he posits that when a country's culture espouses universal values that other states also share, "it increases the probability of achieving desired outcomes" (Nye, 2005, p. 2). Second, the political values that a state practices do affect the perception of other countries. Lastly, the foreign policy of a state is an effective tool for diplomacy when such is perceived to be legitimate and imbued with moral authority. When these three sources of soft power are strategically utilized, a positive global image of a country is fomented, and other states begin to be attracted to it (Kearn, 2011).

In essence, "soft power rests on the ability to shape the preference of others" (Nye, 2004). Aside from the three possible sources, Lee (2009) clarifies that soft power can be further characterized by the following policy goals: First, it can be deployed to improve the external security of a country by conveying a positive image to the world. Moreover, it can be utilized to mobilize support for a country's foreign policy. It can also be used as a tool to influence the preferences of other states. Furthermore, soft power can be positioned to maintain unity among a community of countries. Lastly, it can be utilized to improve the approval rating of a leader and may encourage support for a particular government.

I argue that the strategic deployment of the soft power of states cultivates goodwill with other countries and elevates a country's reputation. For countries with a dearth of hard power, the methodical use of soft power can be employed to compensate for the hard power gap. For countries with a well-established economy and military, soft power can be applied to complement their hard power (Lee, 2011). However, the calculated use of soft power is dependent on states and their priorities. It is within the government's purview to exercise policies that either bolster or squander a country's soft power. Nye (2005) opines that "domestic or foreign policies that appear to be hypocritical, arrogant, indifferent to the opinion of others, or based on a narrow approach to national interests can undermine soft power" (p. 13).

Despite the popularity of the concept and its analytical capacity, scholars have leveled some critiques on the prevailing discourse on

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soft power. Zheng and Zhang (2012) argue that there is a deficiency in Nye's conceptual division between hard and soft power. Specifically, "the effectiveness of certain power resources can be regarded sometimes as 'soft' and sometimes as 'hard,' no matter whether it is military power, economic power, or another type of power" (Zheng & Zhang, 2012, p. 24). Second, the dominant delineations of soft power tend to be simplistic and, in some cases, vague. Kearn (2011) adds that "the implicit assumptions of soft power, which relate to its scope and conditions of use, are often not adequately addressed, contributing to misuse and analytical confusion" (p. 71). Lee (2009) goes further by framing Nye's soft power theory as "hegemonic" and should not be "mechanically copied and imported by lesser powers" (p. 216).

While these critiques of soft power theory are valid, I still regard the concept in a positive light owing to its capacity to examine both tangible and intangible resources as mechanisms of a state's foreign policy. Perhaps, the most appropriate way to characterize soft power is to appreciate it as a social construct, which reveals much about a country's identity and security dynamics (Callahan, 2015). In an increasingly globalized world, states are not only competing through military activities but also through institutions, beliefs, human resources, and cultural attraction (Wang & Lu, 2008). Fundamentally, soft power in international relations has become a state's "means of seduction" (Wilson, 2015). In the succeeding sections, I further unpack China's soft power strategy.

China's Soft Power Arsenal in Perspective

At this juncture, I put into perspective China's soft power strategy and examine some nuanced differences when such is compared with dominant notions of the term. Lo and Pan (2021) point out that China's conception and positioning of soft power may be quite different from the West in terms of norms and values. Likewise, some scholars have even noted that China's soft power strategy lags behind its hard power gains, especially when compared to other major powers (Li, 2008). However, I observed that in the past two decades, China's soft power strategy has

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undergone a considerable transformation. This is best exemplified by its increasing regional presence and global influence. This points to the observation that China's leadership has acknowledged "the importance of soft power in achieving comprehensive national power" (Glaser & Murphy, 2009, p. 16).

Interestingly, the concept of soft power in China's context possesses unique subtleties. Specifically, it can be considered as 軟實力 (*ruan shili*/soft capabilities) or 軟權力 (*ruan quanli*/soft power). Chen and Song (2012) posit that 軟實力 (*ruan shili*/soft capabilities) is more often used, since 軟權力 (*ruan quanli*/soft power) connotes dominance intending to induce changes in the policy of other countries. 軟實力 (*ruan shili*/soft capabilities) can be interpreted as "a defensive way to safeguard the cultural sovereignty of a country, or it could be projected to influence the behavior of other states" (Chen & Song, 2012, p. 51). Turcsanyi and Kachlikova (2020) opine that Chinese understanding of soft power is much more instrumental and direct than Western conceptions, which are primarily indirect and operate through attraction. For example, the Belt and Road Initiative is a direct manifestation of Chinese soft power with the goal of expanding the country's global influence. In the case of the West, specifically the US, soft power is derived from a constellation of sources such as media dominance, internationally recognized brands, and the global pervasiveness of the English language (Hunter, 2009).

Compared to other major powers, China is new in incorporating soft power into its foreign policy and acts of diplomacy (Lee, 2011). China's adoption of soft power was most apparent during the term of President Hu Jintao, when he proposed the goals of "building a harmonious society" and "building a harmonious world" (Zheng & Tok, 2007, p. 9). At the 17th National Congress of the Communist Party of China, Hu Jintao stated his intention to further develop China's soft power (Callahan, 2015). Specifically, he expressed the need to "enhance culture as part of the soft power of our country in order to better guarantee the people's basic cultural rights and interests, to enrich the cultural life in Chinese society" (Zhang, 2010, p. 383). This was a pivotal moment for China

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in the development and inclusion of soft power as part of its national strategy (Edney, 2012).

China more recently capitalized on its foray into soft power through President Xi Jinping's "China Dream" which involves achieving the "Two 100s," specifically being a moderately well-off society by 2021 and transforming into a fully developed country in 2049 (Yang & Yu, 2015). Both 2021 and 2049 are momentous years for China, the former being the centenary of the Chinese Communist Party while the latter is the centenary of the founding of the People's Republic of China. In 2014, Xi Jinping further revealed that there is a need to "increase China's soft power, give a good Chinese narrative, and better communicate China's messages to the world" (Turcsanyi & Kachlikova, 2020, p. 61). Subsequently, China initiated a soft power offensive through initiatives such as the 21st Century Maritime Silk Road and Silk Road Chinese Government Scholarships.

Overall, China's soft power is arrayed through the following strategies: (1) a reassuring political discourse, (2) a moderate stance on highly controversial issues, (3) cultural and public diplomacy, and (4) assistance and trade (Lai, 2012). Li (2008) adds that significant effort has been made to promote China's soft power such as hosting large-scale cultural events abroad, "allotting substantial financial resources allotting substantial financial resources toward cultivating a better image of China, promoting the capacity of its mass media in international communications, and sponsoring Confucius Institutes around the world" (p. 308). To some extent, these strategies have been effective. Some countries from the global south began to positively perceive China as a possible model for economic development (Lee, 2011).

There is a lack of consensus on how soft power ought to be measured; nevertheless, some agencies still attempt to provide a comparative analysis of how countries perform in terms of soft power utilization and perception. One of the most widely considered indices is Soft Power 30, a collaboration between the University of Southern California's Center on Public Diplomacy and Portland, a strategic communications consultancy firm (Keane & Wu, 2021). The index measures seven domains which

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include culture, engagement, education, enterprise, government, digital, and polling data. Figure 1 shows China's soft power rank according to Soft Power 30. China performed well in culture and engagement, while its rank in education dropped a few notches from the previous year. Conversely, it did not perform well on digital, enterprise, government, and polling data. Among 30 countries, China ranked in the 27th position.

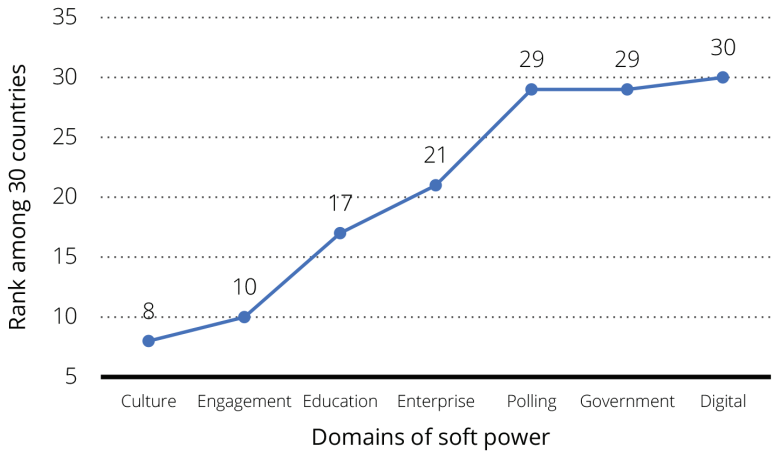


Figure 1. China's soft power rank according to the 2019 Soft Power 30 (Source: University of Southern California, 2019)

Some scholars have noted that China's investment in soft power has not necessarily led to ideal results. In terms of outcomes, Barker (2017) claims that China is not "making a significant dent in world public imagination." Callahan (2015) similarly observes that China seems to "punch below its weight in terms of the international influence expected of a great power" (p. 216). Consequently, a negative perception of China is becoming more apparent because of the COVID-19 pandemic. According to a Pew Research Center survey, a majority of the countries included in

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their study have expressed "an unfavorable opinion of China" (Silver et al., 2020, p. 3). China may have insufficient appeal in the West, but it must be noted that "not everyone is watching China through Western eyes" (Moss, 2013).

As such, China continues to engage with other countries through a host of strategies to improve its global standing and regime legitimacy. Callahan (2015) maintains that there are two important goals in China's usage of soft power, namely creating a favorable image toward foreign audiences and enhancing "regime legitimacy at home" (p. 219). Essentially, soft power is not simply a foreign policy tool but also serves a domestic purpose. Some of the soft power tools that China has in its arsenal are cultural and educational exchanges as well as investment and foreign aid (Lee, 2011). Yang (2007) affirms that China is continuously and consciously promoting educational collaboration and international exchanges as a component of its soft power strategy, which leads to increased legitimacy as an emerging superpower. Wang (2020) adds that educational diplomacy is an important facet of China's overall approach to public diplomacy and economic development. Subsequently, I will elucidate on China's investment in education to leverage its universities as a tool for diplomacy.

China's Higher Education Competitiveness and Its Double World-Class Initiative

Former PRC State Councilor Liu Yandong appealed to universities in China "to serve the nation's diplomatic strategies" (Pan, 2013, p. 253). What this statement implies is the inextricable link between the Chinese state and its universities. Lo and Pan (2021) clarify that China's university governance model is quite different from the West. In general, Western universities seek a high degree of autonomy. Such is not necessarily the case for Chinese universities, since they are expected to adhere to the dictums of the state and align their practices with the government's policies (Lo & Pan, 2020). However, China seems to have replicated

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the West's model for international student recruitment as a facet of their public diplomacy. China has unequivocally expressed its motive of competing with other countries in recruiting international students (Ding, 2016).

Since the 1990s, several policies have been implemented to improve Chinese higher education. In 1993, the Outline for Education Reform and Development in China highlighted the need for educational institutions which are "compatible with socialist market economy institutions, political institutions, science and technology institutions reforms" (Fan, 2020, p. 115). In 1995, the Education Act of the People's Republic of China encouraged cooperation and exchange with foreign partners (Huang, 2010). Project 211 focused on the creation of approximately 112 universities to improve teaching and research quality (Jiang et al., 2020). Subsequently, in 1998, Project 985 or the "world-class university project" led to the creation of "internationally recognized high-level research universities" (Fang, 2012). These policies in the 1990s led to a transformation of China's higher education landscape; its universities "have become competitive on a global scale" (Nzivo & Chen, 2013, p. 129).

Aside from the educational policies and reforms implemented in the 1990s, China also initiated the Thousand Talents Plan in 2008, a recruitment scheme that invited scholars and scientists to fill positions in Chinese academia (Jia, 2018a). Jia (2018b) further maintains that the program recruited more than 7,600 individuals. These overseas talents were incentivized through favorable terms and allowances (Lo & Pan, 2020). Aside from global talent recruitment, China also initiated a program called 雙一流 (*shuang yiliu*) or "double-first class." This is an abridgment of 世界一流大學和一流學科建設 (*shijie yiliu daxue he yiliu xueke jianshe*), which is "world-class universities and first-class disciplines." Through the double world-class initiative, China has envisioned its 42 universities to be included in the 2050 global rankings. For Chinese universities seeking to be "world-class," a significant focus on research productivity in the field of science and technology has been emphasized (Lo & Pan, 2020).

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These policies that were crafted and implemented led to tremendous outcomes for China's scientific production capacity. As shown in Figure 2, the scientific publication output of China significantly increased from 1.42 million in 2010 to 1.95 million in 2020. In 2018, the United States was outranked by China in scientific publication quantity. Consequently, Yang (2017) opines that China has moved from being an imitator to an innovator through its intensive research and development capabilities.

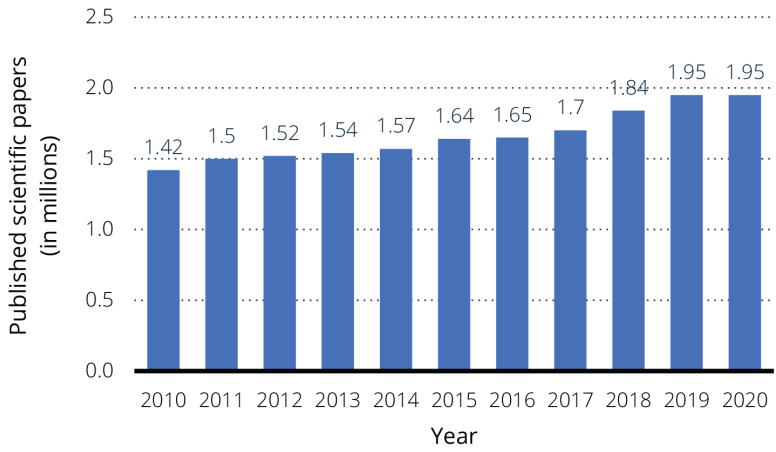


Figure 2. Scientific publication output of China from 2010 to 2020 (Source: National Bureau of Statistics of China, 2021)

In order to meet its goals, China has continuously increased its expenditure on tertiary education. Figure 3 highlights the increase in education spending from CNY 1,011 billion in 2016 to approximately CNY 1,400 billion in 2020. With the increased pull of Chinese universities, international students found studying in China an appealing option (Nzivo & Chen, 2013). Yang (2007) claims that there is an increasing number of international students who are completing undergraduate and postgraduate degrees in China. Equally, Chinese

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universities are also actively recruiting students globally with particular attention to those coming from developing countries (Yang, 2007). Considering China's increasing higher education competitiveness, its universities have become intellectual capital engines "interlinked with global transformations" (Coates, 2020, p. 165). Subsequently, China is capitalizing on its universities and recent triumphs in global rankings to promote international education in accordance with the country's national interests (Yerezhepekova & Torebekova, 2019).

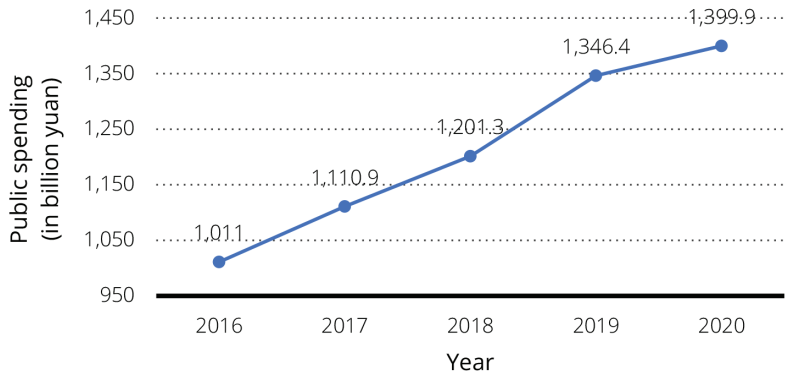


Figure 3. China's public expenditure on tertiary education from 2016 to 2020 (Source: Ministry of Education [China], 2021)

Amirbek and Ydyrys (2014) posit that the existence of educational opportunities for foreign students is a key instrument of soft power by a state. Lo and Pan (2021) maintain that China deploys a strategy-oriented differentiation for student recruitment, with a particular preference for individuals from One Belt, One Road (OBOR) regions. Figure 4 shows the number of foreign students in China. From 377,054 students in 2014, it increased to 492,185 students in 2018. Wilson (2015) affirms this observation and claims that the Chinese government intensified its recruitment of foreign students with the goal of recruiting 500,000

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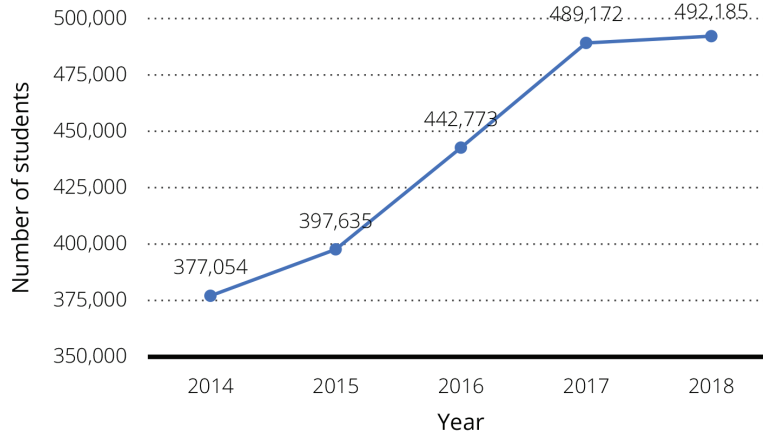


Figure 4. Foreign students studying in China from 2014 to 2018 (Source: Ministry of Education [China], 2019)

by 2020. However, the COVID-19 pandemic precipitated a decline in global student mobility (Altbach & de Wit, 2020). In the case of China, international student intake has taken a severe setback, with foreign students unable to enter the country due to strict public health regulations and border restrictions (Zou & Agyemang, 2022).

Manifestations of Educational Soft Power in Southeast Asia

Southeast Asia is one of the regions that benefit from China's soft power implementation. This is exemplified through increased international student intake, the development of Chinese university's offshore campuses and joint programs, and the rising number of Confucius Institutes. In 2016, the number of Southeast Asian students studying in China was approximately 70,000 (ICEF, 2016). In 2018, the number rose to an estimated 80,000 students (Lau, 2021). Two likely reasons for this increase are the global rank improvement of Chinese universities and the country's burgeoning economic influence (Ahmad & Shah, 2018).

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China, therefore, has a "valuable tool in improving relations with ASEAN countries" (Velasco, 2022, p. 425).

This increase in Southeast Asian student intake by Chinese universities highlights China's efforts to use education as an apparatus of influence in the region. This achieves short-term and long-term effects toward an improved perception of China in Southeast Asia. The short-term effect is what Tian and Lowe (2018) call the "alumnus effect," where graduates of Chinese academic institutions will carry positive nostalgia with respect to their experience in studying in China. Mulvey (2020) highlights that education is indeed a diplomatic tool for China. He illumines that the government of China "invests heavily in recruiting international students to study in Chinese universities, with the rationale that this will lead to improved relations between China and students' respective home countries" (Mulvey, 2019, para. 1). Yousaf et al. (2020) further affirm this observation and claim that Chinese "educational diplomacy is achieving its goal of promulgating positive views of China" (p. 175).

A long-term effect of increased Southeast Asian student intake in Chinese institutions is the gradual reshaping of attitudes toward China. Yang (2007) argues that "training future generations of intellectuals, technicians, and political elites from other nations is a subtle yet important form of soft power" (p. 25). With Southeast Asian alumni of Chinese universities taking positions in various institutions in their home countries, they fulfill "para-diplomatic roles" with the expectation that they will articulate "China's story in a positive way" (Mulvey & Lo, 2021, p. 552).

Aside from recruiting foreign students, China has also initiated moves to establish offshore campuses and joint programs in the region. For example, China established Xiamen University in Malaysia in 2013; this was an attempt by Chinese authorities to internationalize higher education and subsequently stretch its influence (Cheng & Koh, 2022). The Malaysian campus of Xiamen University has been called the "friendship bridge between Malaysia and China" (Jie, 2018, p. 10). Aside from Malaysia, other Southeast Asian countries began to accept

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the development of offshore campuses or programs in cooperation with Chinese universities, e.g., Soochow University in Laos and Thailand's Bangkok Business School in cooperation with Yunnan University of Finance and Economics (Ngeow, 2022).

The most ostensible manifestation of China's educational soft power project to the world is its Confucius Institutes (CI) which promote the Chinese language and culture (Burnay & Pils, 2022). Some scholars have noted that the global deployment of CIs is the primary component of Chinese soft power (Barker, 2017). Generally, CIs are modeled after cultural organizations of the West, e.g., the UK's British Council or Germany's Goethe Institut (Lo & Pan, 2020). However, one unique aspect of CIs is their close integration with local universities—seldom operating without an institutional partnership (Mohamedbhai, 2013). Notably, Confucius Institutes have been linked to concerns such as impingement on academic freedom, inappropriate influence on teaching and research, and engagement in espionage (Yang, 2010; Yuan et al., 2016).

Despite these issues, the presence of Confucius Institutes in the region has been increasing (Yang, 2012). In 2021, there were 31 Confucius Institutes located in various parts of Southeast Asia (Tan, 2022). I observe that Confucius Institutes located in the region do serve a vital role in the deployment of Chinese soft power along with other educational partnerships. Simply put, the operation of Confucius Institutes involves "a complex of soft power technique, using language, education, cultural events, conferences and tourism as non-military and non-economic means to exert China's influence" (Pan, 2013, p. 30).

By using education as an apparatus of influence in Southeast Asia, Chinese academic institutions have been positioned as a tool of diplomacy. Consequently, ASEAN members and universities within the bloc have "started to see China as an attractive partner, especially its top-tier universities" (Yang, 2012, p. 490). However, their soft power efforts in the region are being undermined by ongoing territorial issues, and distrust of China is still pervasive among Southeast Asian populations which can be attributed to geopolitical insecurities and deep historical antagonisms (Gong, 2020).

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Conclusion and Future Directions

In this article, I examined the nuances of China's soft power and demonstrated how such is deployed in the Southeast Asian region. This was accomplished through the analysis of policies pertaining to China's higher education sector and its positioning as a tool for diplomacy. Within the past two decades, China has invested in various means to promote its soft power in the form of cultural activities and educational linkages. In the context of Southeast Asia, China has actively recruited students from the region. Aside from hosting international students from ASEAN, China has also initiated activities such as the development of offshore campuses and aggressively increased the number of Confucius Institutes. Essentially, "China is projecting soft power actively through higher education in the region" (Yang, 2012, p. 486). Through its soft power, China has been able to influence the existing international order and slightly assuage discontent among its neighbors (Lee, 2008).

In order to enrich this area of investigation, I put forward the following recommendations. There is a need to comparatively explore the perception of Southeast Asian populations toward China's projection of soft power ASEAN. Second, it is necessary to put soft power into perspective in relation to the ongoing geopolitical tensions in the region. Specifically, the South China Sea dispute continues to be a regional security issue and "an enduring dilemma for China, the Philippines, and other claimants" (Wu & Velasco, 2022, p. 2). Lastly, given that there is lingering unease about China's motives in the region, examining the dominant discourses of Chinese distrust from Southeast Asia would lead to further productive discussions on both tensions and areas of cooperation in Sino-ASEAN relations.

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